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A Proactive Approach

Within a week of my assuming charge as governor, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh arrived in Itanagar, the capital of Arunachal Pradesh. It was a landmark event and the whole state was eagerly looking forward to it. On this occasion, Dr Singh announced a huge infrastructural development package of over Rs 20,000 crores, including an airport, a rail link to Itanagar, a four-lane highway from Guwahati, a trans-Arunachal highway of over 1500 kms connecting most of the district HQs, and many hydel power projects. This much-needed initiative has launched the state into a new trajectory of growth and development. (A list of these projects is given in Appendix 9.)

This was the first occasion since independence that such a massive development programme was initiated in the state. The prime minister then had a meeting with me and the chief minister and his team of ministers at the Raj Bhawan. He was given a comprehensive briefing about the security situation and the development needs of our state. He stayed with us for the night and the next day, accompanied by the chief minister and me, he flew to Tezu. There, Dr Singh addressed a gathering of army officers and soldiers of a mountain brigade, which is also known as the hathi (elephant) brigade, and had a cup of tea with them. It was a coincidence that I had served as a battalion commander in the same location during 1981–83. The brigade then had an Assam Rifles battalion, which was authorized an elephant as there were numerous rivers and channels which were not bridged and the elephant helped us cross all these obstacles. Prior to the prime minister's visit, I met Chief Minister Dorjee Khandu and his cabinet